

was usually making a par, I wanted to chip in from around the green (for a birdie). Once you start thinking, 'Can I chip in from around the green?' you stop bothering about par. You're aiming higher.

I think in a span of a year or two, I went from six to four to three. Two was my best handicap. I did play scratch, but two was my best.

What were your best scores on some of the overseas courses you played in championship conditions?

I played at Dunhill, at St Andrews, and was two-under. That was around ten years ago.

How did the offer to head the PGTI come your way?

Honestly, I didn't want to be in the PGTI. When Mr Gautam Thapar headed the PGTI for a long time, I used to talk to the players. It came from my love for the game. I used to say, "You deserve a much better life than what you have."

I meant, five to seven crore rupees prize money for 300 people for the whole season? It's not enough. Perhaps the golfers felt my love for the game was deeper. They said I should be part of the PGTI Board. I said I knew nothing about how things worked, but they made me a member four years ago.

You have maintained that the corporate sector could be a source of more money into mainstream golf.

I still believe corporate golf in India is far bigger than professional golf. It has more regular tournaments all round the year. I always say that the people who organise corporate golf should bring that money into the main channel.

Your tenure has seen a huge rise in prize money. What is your vision before you step down as PGTI chief?

We have touched around ₹60 crore this season. I hope we reach ₹100



I GUESS MY CRICKETING MUSCLES COME INTO PLAY WHENEVER I STRIKE THE GOLF BALL HARD

crore within a couple of years, God willing.

How long do you wish to continue in this role?

I don't want to continue after two terms. I believe nobody should remain in one seat longer than they are supposed to. Everyone should get a chance. Every president, every secretary has a job to do — don't overstay.

Do you plan to increase the number of tournaments or increase prize money?

Ideally, I see 20–22 weeks of golf for the top players. For the next line of emerging players, another 10–15 weeks. For second-tier players, they can move from playing in Delhi to smaller cities like Meerut.

Second-tier tournaments are very important. But all this requires money. And I don't want to go to the government. The government's job is to look after other aspects of sport.

We don't want government funds. But if CSR funds can be used, given on this side, we'd be much happier.

What steps do you have in mind for the benefit of players?

At the PGTI, we want a tie-up with some airlines so our players can travel within India for tournaments at discounted fares. I want parity among players at all levels. At the moment we provide free food to all participants and their caddies during tournaments — a step we introduced recently.

Going forward, it will be more specific. Today we provide *roti*, rice, *dal*, *dahi* and *sabzi*. In future, we'll consult dieticians. There are restraints today and players lack awareness. As awareness grows, their diets will improve qualitatively.

Before I let you go, can you share one realistic wish for Indian golf?

If I said an Indian could be in the top 10 in Europe or America in a year or two, that would be very difficult. But realistically, I'm looking for an Olympic medal for India in golf.